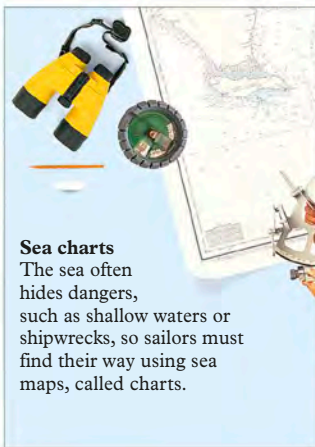




# SAILING SHIPS



Nearly three-quarters of Earth's surface is covered by water, most of it in the seas and oceans. For thousands of years people have been finding ways to cross this water. At first they built rafts, and boats with oars, but around 3200 BCE the Egyptians began to use sails. From then on, sailing ships ruled the seas until a century ago. Today, big ships have engines, but small sailing ships are used for sports, fishing, and local trade.



## Sea charts

The sea often hides dangers, such as shallow waters or shipwrecks, so sailors must find their way using sea maps, called charts.

*Sailors once used an instrument called a sextant to find their way in the middle of the ocean. A sextant helped navigate using the position of the sun or stars.*



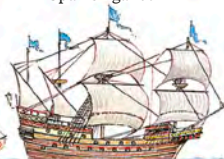
## Across the ocean

For hundreds of years, sailing ships have traveled the oceans of the world for exploration, trade, and war.

15th-century Portuguese caravel



16th-century Spanish galleon



17th-century merchant ship



## A quick tea

A ship's speed is measured in knots—one knot is about 1.85 kmh (1.15 mph). The fastest sailing ships were clippers, such as the Cutty Sark, which had a top speed of 17 knots. It transported tea from China to England in about 100 days.



China tea bundles



## Tall ships

Many of the great ships of the past have been restored and are used today for special "Tall Ships" races.